



T-72

The T-72 was a Soviet tank designed for use if the Cold War had escalated into open conflict. Simple to manufacture and maintain, it followed the T-64 (see p.132), a more expensive and complex tank. The T-72 entered service with the Red Army in the 1970s and is still used by over 40 countries. Versions of the T-72, often with lower standards of protection, were built in the Soviet Union for exportation, while Poland and Czechoslovakia also manufactured T-72s.

THE T-72 INCLUDED FEATURES from earlier Soviet tank designs—a low profile, a frying pan-shaped turret, and a reliable diesel engine. At just over 45 tons (41 tonnes), it was relatively light compared to contemporary Western tanks. It was also considered less effective than its Western rivals in one-on-one encounters, as with many Soviet tanks of the Cold War. However, it was fit for purpose: Soviet commanders intended to use it in huge massed attacks to swamp western defenses.

The T-72 was equipped with an autoloader system for the main gun, with 22 rounds housed in a circular, horizontal carousel; 17 extra rounds were stored in the hull. This allowed a maximum rate of fire of up to three shots in 13 seconds. It also meant that a three-man crew could be used (commander, gunner, and driver), reducing the need for crew space and enabling a smaller, lighter design. This was so effective that official guidelines specified a maximum height of 5 ft 9 in (175 cm) for crewmen, to ensure they could fit into the T-72’s cramped interior.



REAR VIEW



SPECIFICATIONS	
Name	T-72M1
Date	1973
Origin	Soviet Union
Production	Over 25,000
Engine	V46.6 V-12 diesel, 780 hp
Weight	45.7 tons (41.5 tonnes)
Main armament	125 mm 2A46M smoothbore
Secondary armament	12.7 mm NSVT machine gun
Crew	3
Armor thickness	Max 11in (280 mm)

Driver

Gunner

Commander